Knowledge is power and, in critical situations, often more than that. In a competitive world, this puts a premium on intelligence, assessments and understanding. In a battlefield situation, insights and information can be a veritable trump card. And indeed, this is exactly what we see unfolding in the Ramayana.

The battle between Lakshmana and Indrajit, Ravana's son, is considered in many ways to be the turning point before the final denouement. Its setting is preceded by a 'psy-ops', where Indrajit created a virtual Sita and killed her in the presence of the monkey army. He then sought to use the resulting confusion to complete an *asuric* sacrifice that would make him invincible. It is here that knowledge makes a difference. His uncle Vibheeshana understood exactly what he was doing and counselled Rama accordingly. Lakshmana was sent to Nikumbhila to prevent the completion of the sacrifice. After battling for three days and nights, he killed Indrajit by using the *Indrastra*.

There is also a preceding encounter with another son of Ravana, the giant Atikaya, where inside information makes a difference. Struggling to hold his end up in the duel, Lakshmana was advised by Vayu that only the *Brahmashakti* can kill this demon, which it did, much to his relief. Indeed, Rama himself was the beneficiary of his charioteer Matali's advice to use the *Brahmastra* against Ravana at the crucial moment of their battle. Clearly, informationized warfare provides not just an edge but can be a complete game-changer.

If there is an underestimated character in Ramayana, it is Ravana's younger brother Vibheeshana. Perhaps his disassociation from the parent clan, even for virtuous reasons, left a taint in the public mind. But the fact remains that at the turning points of this saga, he made a crucial contribution. This was something that Lord Rama understood and anticipated when he welcomed him into his ranks despite the reservations of his advisers. He sensed Vibheeshana's ambition to replace Ravana and, significantly, crowned him as the king of Lanka before the battle began. Apparently, regime change has a long history!

On his part, Vibheeshana provided invaluable information through a network built by his allies Anal, Sampati, Pramati and Panas. It was to him that Rama continuously turned for tactical intelligence during the course of the war. And when Rama and Lakshmana were disabled by Indrajit using the *Nagapash*, it was Vibheeshana who gained time for their recovery. Adopting from the ranks of adversaries is always a tricky situation. There are inbuilt doubts and suspicions to that process. But as Lord Rama demonstrated, it really pays off when this is not just sound judgment in the beginning but also the courage to stick to that call through trying times.

A related aspect is the power of the narrative. If assiduously built up, it becomes the basis for dominance, where even the will to resist can be weakened. Ravana is generally regarded as invincible until he was defeated by Rama. The reality, however, was a little different, and it is to Ravana's credit that he was able to create such an effective reputation. That he defeated virtually all his contemporaries was crucial in this projection. So, too, was the fact that his son Meghanada was able to vanquish the king of gods (Indra), thereby earning the sobriquet Indrajit. But it was also true that, on occasion, Ravana was bested in combat and forced to accept that outcome. Among those who defeated him was Vali, when Ravana sought to capture him in the midst of his meditations. There was also an encounter with King Kartavirya Arjuna of Mahishmati that went rather badly. They both happened to be immersing themselves in the Ganga at the same time, and Arjuna's activities interrupted Ravana in the midst of his worship. In the ensuing battle, Ravana was captured and taken back as a prisoner to Mahishmati. It finally took the intervention of his grandfather, Sage Pulastya, to secure his release. In both cases, Ravana not only beat a retreat but came to a compromise with his adversaries.